

tough issues rather than “sue the bastard.” Foreign courts rarely see the kinds of absurdities the U.S. system must process.

But there are certain legal problems abroad. In much of the Third World your civil rights will not be protected to the extent you’re used to. Civil rights mean little to dictators. In many countries you’re considered guilty until proven innocent.

How do you keep out of trouble? Avoid politics and politicians. Avoid talking about politics and politicians. Avoid giving anyone the impression that you even think about politics and politicians.

Respect local laws and customs. In Milwaukee greasing a cop is a serious crime; smoking marijuana is a misdemeanor. Not so abroad. In Rio you’ll see to it that your neighborhood cop gets a couple of bucks every once in a while. And smoking marijuana can get you 25 years in prison.

SOME PERSONAL ADVICE

After years of travel and living abroad, Vicki and I have come up with the Three Cs:

Don’t criticize, complain, or compare

Don’t criticize. Remember you’re a guest in a foreign country. Guests don’t criticize their hosts. Rather, they point out the good things.

Don’t complain. Complaining is for children and losers. Winners are too busy enjoying themselves to complain about minor irritants. They roll with the punches and see the positive in what they find.

Don’t compare. Comparing is almost always debilitating. It’s one thing to tell me a steak is good, bad, overcooked, salty, or tender. I know what those terms mean. It’s quite another to tell me a steak is better or worse than the one you had the night before. Or last year in Texas. Or ten years ago